

Drug Abuse in Pakistan: An Overview with Facts and Figures

Drug abuse remains a significant public health challenge in Pakistan, affecting various segments of society and posing substantial socio-economic and health-related consequences.

Prevalence and Demographics

- **Overall Drug Use:** As of 2013, approximately 6% of Pakistan's population aged 15 to 64 were reported to use drugs, equating to around 6.7 million individuals. [AMHSR Journals+1EMRO+1](#)
- **Gender Distribution:** The majority of drug users are male, accounting for 78%, while females constitute 22% of the drug-using population. [Nation](#)
- **Youth Vulnerability:** Nearly 25% of drug users are under the age of 18, highlighting a concerning trend among the youth. [PMC](#)

Commonly Abused Substances

- **Cannabis:** The most commonly used drug, with an annual prevalence of 3.6%, corresponding to approximately 4 million users. [Wikipedia](#)
- **Opioids:** About 2.4% of the adult population uses opioids, including heroin and opium. [EMRO](#)
- **Heroin:** Over 800,000 individuals aged 15 to 64 are regular heroin users, consuming an estimated 44 tons annually. [Nation+1Wikipedia+1](#)

Regional Variations

- **Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP):** Approximately 11% of the population in KP is reported to use drugs, primarily cannabis. [Nation](#)
- **Balochistan:** In 2013, there were about 280,000 drug users in the province. [Nation](#)

Injection Drug Use and Associated Risks

- **Increase in Injection Drug Users (IDUs):** The number of IDUs in Punjab escalated from an estimated 90,000 in 2007 to around 500,000 by 2014. [Nation+1Wikipedia+1](#)
- **HIV Prevalence:** HIV positivity among IDUs increased from 11% in 2005 to 40% in 2011, indicating a severe public health concern. [Nation+1Wikipedia+1](#)

Mortality Rates

- **Drug-Related Deaths:** Approximately 700 individuals die daily due to drug-related complications and overdoses, totaling around 250,000 deaths annually. [Lippincott Journals](#)

Economic Impact

- **Illegal Drug Trade:** Pakistan's illegal drug trade is estimated to generate up to \$2 billion annually, exacerbating socio-economic challenges. [Wikipedia+1Nation+1](#)

Current Initiatives

- **National Drug Use Survey 2022-24:** Launched by the Ministry of Narcotics Control in collaboration with international partners, this survey aims to provide updated data on drug use patterns to inform policy and intervention strategies.
[PMC+2UNODC+2Lippincott Journals+2](#)

Conclusion

The pervasive issue of drug abuse in Pakistan necessitates comprehensive and coordinated efforts encompassing prevention, treatment, and policy reforms to mitigate its impact on individuals and society.